CAMBRIDGE
International Education

Cambridge O Level

BIOLOGY **5090/22**

Paper 2 Theory **October/November 2025**

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 80

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

Cambridge International is publishing the mark schemes for the October/November 2025 series for most Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge International A and AS Level components, and some Cambridge O Level components.

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PUBLISHED

Generic Marking Principles

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5:

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Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).
GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6: Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

Science-Specific Marking Principles

1	Examiners should consider the context and scientific use of any keywords when awarding marks. Although keywords may be present, marks should not be awarded if the keywords are used incorrectly.
2	The examiner should not choose between contradictory statements given in the same question part, and credit should not be awarded for any correct statement that is contradicted within the same question part. Wrong science that is irrelevant to the question should be ignored.
3	Although spellings do not have to be correct, spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. ethane / ethene, glucagon / glycogen, refraction / reflection).
4	The error carried forward (ecf) principle should be applied, where appropriate. If an incorrect answer is subsequently used in a scientifically correct way, the candidate should be awarded these subsequent marking points. Further guidance will be included in the mark scheme where necessary and any exceptions to this general principle will be noted.
5	<u>'List rule' guidance</u> For questions that require ***n*** responses (e.g. State **two** reasons …): • The response should be read as continuous prose, even when numbered answer spaces are provided. • Any response marked *ignore* in the mark scheme should not count towards ***n***. • Incorrect responses should not be awarded credit but will still count towards ***n***. • Read the entire response to check for any responses that contradict those that would otherwise be credited. Credit should **not** be awarded for any responses that are contradicted within the rest of the response. Where two responses contradict one another, this should be treated as a single incorrect response. • Non-contradictory responses after the first ***n*** responses may be ignored even if they include incorrect science.

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6 Calculation specific guidance

Correct answers to calculations should be given full credit even if there is no working or incorrect working, **unless** the question states 'show your working'.

For questions in which the number of significant figures required is not stated, credit should be awarded for correct answers when rounded by the examiner to the number of significant figures given in the mark scheme. This may not apply to measured values.

For answers given in standard form (e.g. $a \times 10^n$) in which the convention of restricting the value of the coefficient (a) to a value between 1 and 10 is not followed, credit may still be awarded if the answer can be converted to the answer given in the mark scheme.

Unless a separate mark is given for a unit, a missing or incorrect unit will normally mean that the final calculation mark is not awarded. Exceptions to this general principle will be noted in the mark scheme.

7 Guidance for chemical equations

Multiples / fractions of coefficients used in chemical equations are acceptable unless stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

State symbols given in an equation should be ignored unless asked for in the question or stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

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Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standard isation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
	correct point or mark awarded
	incorrect point or mark not awarded
	information missing or insufficient for credit
	allow or accept
	insufficient point ignored while marking the rest of the response
	contradiction in response, mark not awarded
	benefit of the doubt given
	error carried forward applied

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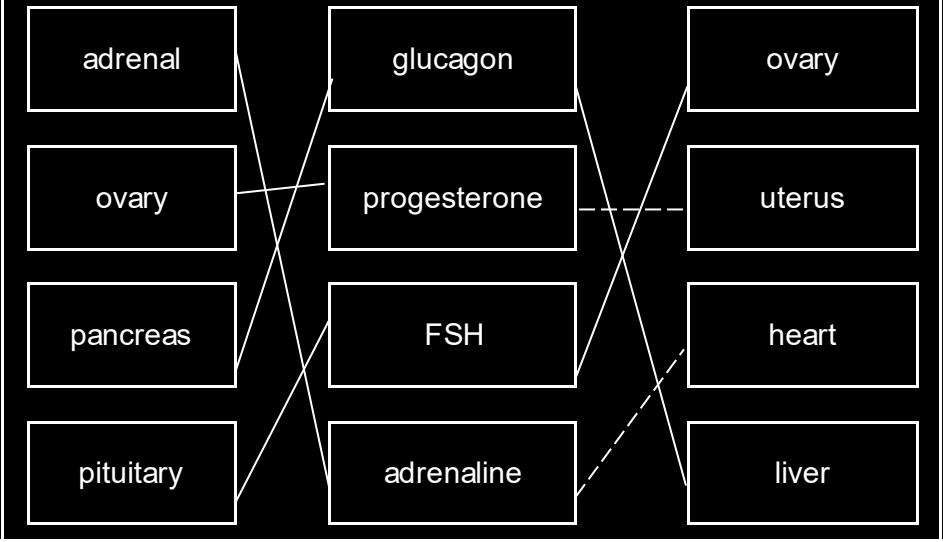
Annotation	Meaning
	point has been noted but no credit has been given or blank page seen
	correct idea but not specific enough
	used to highlight parts of an extended response
	key point attempted / working towards marking point
Ruler	allows lengths to be measured
Protractor	allows angles to be measured
Multi-line Overlay	overlays graphs
	correct, awarding one mark from marking point 1.
	correct, awarding one mark from marking point 2, similar numbered ticks are used for marking point 3, 4, 5 etc.

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Mark Scheme abbreviations

;	separates marking points
/	alternative responses for the same marking point
R	reject the response
A	accept the response
I	ignore the response
ecf	error carried forward
AVP	any valid point
ora	or reverse argument
AW	alternative wording
underline	actual word given must be used by candidate (grammatical variants excepted)
( )	the word / phrase in brackets is not required but sets the context
max	indicates the maximum number of marks that can be given
mp	marking point

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(a)		**5**	left side of diagram: number of marks = number of correct lines right side of diagram: 2 correct lines = 1 mark – – – – – = given to candidates in the question any additional lines to or from a box negates that mark.
1(b)	auxin ;	**1**	

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(a)(i)	8 ;;	**2**	**A** 200 ÷ 2500 **or** 0.08 = 1 mark
2(a)(ii)	max **three** from: 1 homeostasis ; 2 maintaining constant body temperature ; 3 evaporation of sweat to remove heat (energy) ; 4 increased activity / increase in temperature means more sweat / ora ; 5 if volume lost in faeces / lungs / urine changes, then the percentage lost in sweat will change ;	**3**	
2(b)(i)	transpiration ;	**1**	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(b)(ii)	max **two** from: increased water loss **+** during light / day / 0–15 hours / around sunrise **+** stomata open ; decreased water loss **+** during dark / night / 15–21 hours / around sunset **+** stomata close ; greater light intensity **+** faster evaporation / more diffusion / ora ;	**2**	
2(b)(iii)	max **three** from: 1 water evaporates / transpires from leaves ; 2 this reduces water potential of leaves ; 3 water moves up / through xylem vessels ; 4 transpiration pull / transpiration stream ; 5 forces of attraction between water ; 6 prevents loss of turgidity / prevents wilting ;	**3**	
2(b)(iv)	same shape of curve but below the original ;	**1**	

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
3(a)(i)	max **two** from: chloroplasts ; cell walls ; multicellular ;	**2**	
3(a)(ii)	seeds / fruits **+** spores / gametes ;	**1**	must be in correct order

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
3(b)	max **three** from: 1 nitrogen-fixing bacteria **+** (production of) nitrates ; 2 (nitrates) enter water / soil ; 3 rice **+** absorbs nitrates ; 4 makes proteins / amino acids ; 5 proteins / amino acids are used for growth ;	**3**	
3(c)(i)	max **four** from: 1 carbon dioxide diffuses / enters through stomata ; 2 photosynthesis ; 3 carbon dioxide and water ; 4 glucose formed ; 5 starch stored ;	**4**	**A** equation = 2 marks (mp 3 + 4**)**
3(c)(ii)	max **three** from: 1 removes carbon dioxide ; 2 (decreases) greenhouse gas / effect ; 3 (reduces) global warming / heat (energy) trapped ; 4 (reduces) climate change ; 5 example of climate change ;	**3**	mp 2,3 and 4: response **must** mention reduce / decrease at least once
3(d)	max **three** from: 1 competition (with Azolla) ; 2 (for) named resource ; 3 no natural consumers / pathogens ; 4 can bring in new diseases ; 5 <u>eutrophication</u> ; 6 increased nitrates / ammonium / ammonia causes increased plant growth ; 7 reduction in biodiversity / loss of species ;	**3**	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
4(a)	speeds up (chemical) reactions ; not changed ;	**2**	
4(b)(i)	pancreas ;	**1**	
4(b)(ii)	*substrate* lipid / fat / oil ; *products* fatty acid(s) **+** glycerol ;	**2**	
4(c)(i)	max **three** from: lipases from A, B and C are active between 40 and 85 °C ; all have different optimum temperatures ; A optimum 40 °C / B optimum 60 °C / C optimum 75 °C ; B most suitable **+** highest activity / A most suitable **+** works best at lower temperatures (40 °C) ;	**3**	**A** name all 3 optimums = 2 marks (for mp 2 + 3)
4(c)(ii)	max **two** from: 1 DNA codes for protein / polypeptide ; 2 sequence of bases ; 3 (determines) sequence of amino acids ; 4 enzymes/lipases are proteins / made of amino acids ; 5 sequence of amino acids determines shape / function ; **and** 6 some enzymes / proteins / structures / active sites denature at lower / higher / different temperatures than others ;	**3**	

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>5(a)(i)</td><td>plasma ;
water ;

max three from:

examples of solutes
glucose ;
amino acids ;
urea ;
mineral ions ;
vitamins ;
fatty acids/glycerol ;</td><td>5</td><td>

A named mineral
A named vitamin</td></tr>
<tr><td>5(a)(ii)</td><td>max two from:

1 haemoglobin ;
2 (densely) packed ;
3 contains iron ;
4 less water / solvent in red blood cells / ora ;
5 solutes increase density ;</td><td>2</td><td></td></tr>
<tr><td>5(b)</td><td><table><tr><th>blood group</th><th>genotype</th></tr><tr><td>A</td><td>$I^A I^A + I^A I^O$;</td></tr><tr><td>B</td><td>$I^B I^B + I^B I^O$;</td></tr><tr><td>AB</td><td>$I^A I^B$;</td></tr><tr><td>O</td><td>$I^O I^O$;</td></tr></table></td><td>4</td><td>each correct row in table = 1 mark</td></tr>
<tr><td>5(c)(i)</td><td>fetus = $I^B I^O$;</td><td>1</td><td></td></tr>
</table>

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
5(c)(ii)	max **three** from: placenta ; separate blood stream ; antibodies too big ; antibodies cannot pass across placenta / through capillary walls ;	**3**	

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
6(a)(i)	bacterium / bacteria ;	**1**	
6(a)(ii)	max **three** from: 1 transmitted / spread through drinking water ; 2 poor <u>sanitation</u> ; 3 *idea that* water supplies are contaminated ; 4 removal of sewage is disrupted ; 5 difficulties with waste disposal / personal hygiene / food preparation ;	**3**	
6(b)(i)	max **four** from: 1 toxin / choleragen ; 2 stimulates release of chloride ions into <u>small</u> intestine ; 3 water passes into intestine / gut ; 4 from high to low water potential ; 5 (by) osmosis ; 6 makes faeces watery ;	**4**	
6(b)(ii)	replaces water / rehydrates ; chloride / ions replaced ;	**2**	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
7(a)	max **four** from: 1 cell is the basic unit of life ; 2 cell **+** light receptor / rods / cones ; 3 tissue is a group of cells with a similar structure / function ; 4 tissue **+** retina / cornea / muscle / sclera / iris / conjunctiva / suspensory ligament ; 5 organ is group of tissues with specific function ; 6 organ **+** eye / optic nerve ;	**4**	
7(b)	1 vesicles contain / release neurotransmitter ; 2 vesicles only on one side of (synaptic) gap ; 3 impulse causes neurotransmitter to be released into gap ; 4 (neurotransmitter) diffuses across gap ; 5 (neurotransmitter) binds to receptor / protein ; 6 receptors / proteins in cell membrane only on other side of gap ;	**6**	

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Appendix – additional guidance for marking responses from candidates who have used braille papers

The table below lists modifications made on the braille paper only where a different approach to marking is required.
In all cases, use your professional judgement when marking and add a comment if required. If in doubt, contact your assessmen t manager.

Note: that the script will be in one of the following three formats:
- Word-processed
- Handwritten by a scribe
- Braille hard copy with handwritten transcription

Question	Modification	Marks	Marking guidance
1(a)	The layout of the question was changed to make it more accessible for Braille candidates. Candidates now choose words to complete sentences rather than draw lines. adrenal – adrenaline – heart given to candidates as an example.	**5**	(i) progesterone (ii) uterus (iii) glucagon (iv) liver (v) FSH (vi) ovary All 6 correct = 5 marks 4 or 5 correct = 4 marks 3 correct = 3 marks 2 correct = 2 marks 1 correct = 1 mark
2(b)(iv)	For braille candidates the layout of the question has been changed. Candidates have been asked to describe the curve.	**1**	same shape but below the original curve ;
3(a)(ii)	The question has been reworded as ‘Name the structures that *Azolla* produce to enable them to reproduce sexually’.	**1**	spores ;

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Question	Modification	Marks	Marking guidance
5(a)(i)	Question layout has been changed due to complexities of the figure. There are now separate questions about the figure rather than completing the figure. Answers align with those on the standard paper.	**5**	(a) plasma ; (b) water ; (c) *any **three from** examples of solutes:* glucose ; amino acids ; urea ; mineral ions ; vitamins ;
5(b)	Layout of question has been changed to show gaps on the table that need completing. (i) indicates first row on table and so on.	**4**	(i) $\mathbf{I^A\ I^A + I^A\ I^O}$; (ii) $\mathbf{I^B\ I^B + I^B\ I^O}$; (iii) $\mathbf{I^A\ I^B}$; (iv) $\mathbf{I^O\ I^O}$;

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